

Old English influences

A more familiar-sounding form of English began when the Anglo-Saxons came from continental Europe to England in about the fifth century CE. English from this time is now referred to as Old English and it was related to German. Modern English words that derive from Old English usually have one or two syllables, and refer to everyday things, such as food, animals, parts of the body and family relationships. Old English words are usually spelled differently from the modern equivalent, but they are often pronounced in a similar way.

aepl

This is Old English for “apple.”



lang

This is Old English for “long.”



helm

This is Old English for “helmet.”



French influences

One of the languages that has influenced English the most is French—a Latin-based language. This is because for about 300 years after the Norman Conquest in 1066, the most powerful people in England spoke a form of French called Norman. For this reason, many English words relating to government, law, money, and warfare come from the French language.

parler

This French word means “to speak” and is the origin of the English word *parliament*.

recrue

This French word refers to untrained soldiers and is the origin of the English word *recruit*.

saudier

This French word refers to a person who is paid for military service and is the origin of the English word *soldier*.

Other influences

There are many other languages that have influenced English over time. For example, the English words *bangle* and *shampoo* derive from Hindi words, and *alligator* and *canoe* derive from Spanish words.

The most famous remnant of **Old English** is *Beowulf*. This epic poem survives in a **single manuscript** dating to sometime between the **eighth and eleventh centuries CE**. The author’s identity remains a mystery.

Language of origin	Examples
French	ballet, cuisine
German	hamburger, kindergarten
Italian	fresco, graffiti
Spanish	anchovy, bonanza
Dutch	cookie, tulip
Arabic	algebra, giraffe
Sanskrit	guru, karma
Hindi	bandanna, cheetah
Persian	balcony, lilac
Russian	gulag, mammoth
Czech	pistol, robot
Norwegian	fjord, ski
Dravidian (Indian subcontinent)	mango, peacock
African languages	jumbo, zombie
American Indian languages	chocolate, igloo
Chinese	ketchup, tea
Japanese	origami, tsunami